Sri Advaita Acharya

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Maha-Vishnu in the Form of a Devotee

The lives of Mahaprabhu's companions almost always tell of parshadas — eternal servants of the Lord who descend into the world with Him, or at another time, to take part in His lilas. Sri Advaita Acharya has to be read differently. He conducts Himself as one of the companions, but in truth He is Maha-Vishnu Himself, the purusha-avatara by whose will the universes arise, come in the form of a devotee. So the Gosvamis of Vrindavana teach, and so says Svarupa Damodara in the verses with which Kaviraja Gosvami opens the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”:

“Lord Advaitacharya is the incarnation of Maha-Vishnu, who creates this whole world by means of His external energy, Maha-Maya.” (CC, Adi 1.12)

The next verse explains His name as well: He is called Advaita, “non-different,” because He is non-different from Hari, the Supreme Lord, and Acharya because He teaches the sacred path of bhakti; He is the Supreme Himself, come as His own devotee (CC, Adi 1.13). Therefore all that is told below — His “not knowing,” His “tests,” His discipleship, His disputes and punishments — is not the story of an ascetic rising towards God, but the lila of the Lord Himself, who has taken on the role of a servant.

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains how creation takes place. Maya acts in two ways, and Maha-Vishnu as the creator appears in two forms: as the efficient cause, nimitta-karana, in the form of Vishnu; and in the pradhana, the primeval ground of matter, in the form of Rudra — and this second identity of His is Advaita[1]. And Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, commenting on the verse of the “Charitamrita” that Advaita bestows good upon the whole world (Adi 6.12), writes: Advaita is Maha-Vishnu, the supreme teacher of the world and the root of all good; whoever cannot understand that everything that comes from Him — even what seems tangled and hard in this world — is pure, eternal and complete good, deprives himself of devotion to Krishna.

In the Pancha-tattva Sri Chaitanya is the bhakta-rupa, the Lord in the form of a devotee; Nityananda is the bhakta-svarupa, His manifestation as a devotee; and Advaita is the bhakta-avatara, the descent of God as a devotee. All three are Prabhus, vishnu-tattva, and therefore tulasi is offered at Their feet, as at the feet of Vishnu. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains: the purusha-avatara Maha-Vishnu, accepting the mood of a devotee, appears in the world as Advaita. Krishnadasa Kaviraja speaks of the Three Prabhus thus:

“One of Them is Mahaprabhu, and the other two are Prabhus. These two Prabhus serve the lotus feet of Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Adi 7.14)[2]

Sri Chaitanya is the body of the movement of bhakti, and Nityananda and Advaita are its limbs; Nityananda, non-different from Baladeva, Sankarshana-Vishnu, and Advaita, “Acharya Gosvami,” are the two “angas” of Sri Chaitanya, two parts of His body. In the image of the tree of devotion with which Kaviraja Gosvami describes the Lord's companions, Mahaprabhu Himself is the main trunk, and Advaita and Nityananda are two secondary trunks:

“Above, the trunk divides into two great branches. One branch is Sri Advaita, and the other branch is Nityananda.” (CC, Adi 9.21)

“I offer obeisances to Advaitachandra, the second extension of the trunk of the eternal tree of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, and to all the branches and twigs — His countless followers.” (CC, Adi 12.3)

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, opening his account of Navadvipa on the eve of the Lord's appearance, places Advaita before all its Vaishnavas:

“In Navadvipa at that time lived Advaita Acharya, the greatest Vaishnava, renowned throughout the world.” (CB, Adi 2.78)

“He was a venerable spiritual teacher, equal to Shiva himself in explaining the science of devotion to Sri Krishna, and the essence of true knowledge and renunciation.” (CB, Adi 2.79)

And Mahaprabhu Himself, telling Vallabha Bhatta in His humility that He knows nothing of devotion, names those whose company purified His heart — and Advaita first:

“But I was fortunate to have the company of Advaitacharya — the Supreme Himself. Because of this My mind was purified.” (CC, Antya 7.17)

“He has no equal in knowledge of the scriptures on devotion to Krishna. Therefore He is called Advaita Acharya, the incomparable Teacher.” (CC, Antya 7.18)

“By His mercy even an eater of flesh can attain Krishna-bhakti. Can anyone fully understand or describe the greatness of His loving service to Krishna?” (CC, Antya 7.19)

Narottama Dasa Thakura, in a song addressed to Sitapati, “the husband of Sita,” begs Advaita for mercy: without it one cannot attain service either to Chaitanya or to Nityananda. But the same truth has another side. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says:

“One who glorifies Advaita Acharya as the foremost of Vaishnavas is a true Vaishnava. In every birth he will be bound to Krishna.” (CB, Madhya 10.162)

And Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains in the “Gaudiya-bhashya”: whoever sees in Advaita the best of Vaishnavas is a Vaishnava; but whoever considers Him the vishaya, the object of love — that is, Krishna Himself — and Sri Chaitanya His ashraya, His loving servant, will not reach the feet of Krishna. Advaita is non-different from Hari, but in His lila He is the servant of Gaura, and wishes to be known precisely so.

Sadashiva

Speaking of who Advaita is in the lilas of Krishna, the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (76–80) calls Him Sadashiva — a manifestation of the Lord in Vraja, non-different from Chaitanya. Kavi Karnapura also cites a tradition from the “Shiva-tantra,” told by Bhairava. Once in the month of Karttika, at the festival of lamps, the Dipa-yatra, Shankara-deva, Bhairava's guru, saw Krishna and Balarama dancing among the cowherd boys, and himself longed to become a cowherd boy — and whirled into their dance. So by Krishna's mercy Sadashiva in Vraja is twofold: he is both Shiva himself and a cowherd boy dancing with Krishna. Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” calls Advaita Mahesha: “Mahesha Thakura went forth before all: He was born in a brahmana family, named Kamalaksha” (CM, Sutra-khanda, part 8, v. 600); and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, in his summary of that chapter, says briefly: Shiva came as Advaita Prabhu[3].

Names

His earlier name was Sri Kamalaksha Veda-panchanana; according to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” Kamalaksha, or Kamalakanta, Veda-panchanana.

The “Charitamrita” explains each of His names. He is Mangala, “auspiciousness,” for He bestows good upon the whole world (Adi 6.12). He is Advaita:

“Sri Advaita is a manifestation of Maha-Vishnu and the source of all divine qualities. He is called Advaita because He is in every way equal to the Supreme.” (CC, Adi 6.25)

He is Acharya, for He is wholly engaged in preaching bhakti and has become the teacher of all devotees; the two names together — Advaita Acharya — make up His full name (Adi 6.28–29). And He is called Kamalaksha, “Lotus-eyed,” because He is a part of the body of the lotus-eyed Lord:

“Because He is an expansion, or a part of the body, of the lotus-eyed Lord, all also call Him Kamalaksha (Lotus-eyed).” (CC, Adi 6.30)[4]

Mahaprabhu affectionately called Him “Nara”[5]. He is also called “Acharya Gosvami,” and the Lord Himself in the “Charitamrita” calls Him “Acharya Gosai” (Antya 12.70); Narottama in his song calls Him Sitapati.

Appearance in Shrihatta

Advaita's father was Kuvera Pandita, a Varendra brahmana — according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (81), Kubera, the friend of Mahadeva and leader of the guhyakas. His mother was named Nabha Devi[6]. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2041–2043) tells of them: Kuvera, a worshipper of Nrisimha, lived in Navagrama near Sylhet; fortune attended him on the path of bhakti, and he knew nothing but the feet of Krishna; and his faithful wife Nabha Devi is worthy of the worship of the whole world — for she became the mother of Advaita.

Advaita's parents lived for a time in Shantipura on the Ganga, and there they saw a prophetic dream. A wondrous person was asking another to take birth in the world to relieve the sufferings of the people of the age of Kali, and said that He Himself would come later. Having received this sign, the couple returned to their home in Navagrama (Navegrama) in Shrihatta (Sylhet), and there a son was born to them[7].

He appeared on the seventh lunar day of the bright fortnight of the month of Magha — on Maghi shukla-saptami, which has ever since been called Advaita-saptami. In our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math) this day — Gaura-saptami of the month of Madhava — is marked as “The Appearance of the Avatara of Maha-Vishnu, Sri Advaita Acharya.” A song of Ghanashyama in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (12.1759–1762) celebrates the day: the “moon” of Advaita rose from the womb of Nabha Devi; Kuvera gave gifts to brahmanas and the poor, stole into the birth chamber and rejoiced to see his son's face; the villagers wondered by what merit such a son was granted to an old man, and the gods, unseen by men, showered the house with flowers.

According to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” He appeared in 1434. He was fifty-two years older than Mahaprabhu — when the Lord appeared, Advaita was fifty-two — and seventeen years older than Haridasa Thakura (who, according to the “Advaita-vilasa,” was born in 1451). The same “Abhidhana” says that He remained on earth until 1559 and departed at the age of one hundred and twenty-five, and the “Advaita-vilasa,” that He stayed in the world “a century and a quarter”[8]. From Shrihatta He moved to Shantipura on the Bhagirathi, not far from Navadvipa.

Study and Pilgrimage

According to the “Prema-vilasa,” Advaita studied the Vedas and other scriptures under Shantacharya in Phullabati — one of the quarters of Shantipura — and received from him the title “acharya”[9]. When Kuvera and Nabha Devi left this world, He went to Gaya on the pretext of performing the funeral rites, and from there set out to wander through the holy places of India.

In Mithila, the “Advaita-vilasa” relates, He met Vidyapati. The great Maithili poet was by then very old; in a sweet voice he recited his verses about Krishna, and the young pilgrim and the old poet glorified

each other. The songs of Vidyapati, a mahajana, were later sung before Mahaprabhu in Puri.

In Vraja Advaita stayed for a long time beneath a banyan tree in Vrindavana. The place is called Advaita-vata: whoever sees it is purified and attains the love of the gopis. There He became absorbed in the worship of Krishna and in meditation understood that Krishna was about to appear in Navadvipa. From Vrindavana He returned to Shantipura, staying a few days in Navadvipa on the way, and the people of Shantipura, who had long pined without Him, were overjoyed.

Disciple of Madhavendra Puri

Advaita's guru was Sri Madhavendra Puri — he whose disciple Ishvara Puri gave initiation to the Lord Himself, and whom Mahaprabhu called the original source of ecstatic love for Krishna. How and when they met is told in different ways[10]. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says that long before the Lord's appearance Madhavendra, in his wanderings, came to Advaita's dwelling in Shantipura: Advaita saw in him all the signs of a true Vaishnava and bowed down before him, and Madhavendra embraced Him and bathed Him in tears of love. They became so absorbed in talk of Krishna that they forgot their bodies, and Advaita accepted instruction from him (CB, Antya 4.433–440). The “Charitamrita” names the occasion as well: Madhavendra, at the command of Gopala, was going to Puri for sandalwood, and on his way through Bengal stopped at Advaita's house:

“Reaching Shantipura, he visited the house of Advaitacharya. Seeing the divine love of Madhavendra Puri, He rejoiced.” (CC, Madhya 4.110)

“He asked Madhavendra Puri for initiation into the mantra. Madhavendra gave Him initiation and went on further south.” (CC, Madhya 4.111)

From Shantipura Madhavendra went south, to Remuna.

Advaita is Maha-Vishnu Himself; why should He need a guru? He accepted initiation to show conditioned souls that one cannot do without a guru — just as Mahaprabhu Himself accepts initiation from Ishvara Puri. Vrindavana Dasa says that Advaita only played the role of Madhavendra's disciple[11].

Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 1.4.5–6) binds them still more closely: one portion of the Lord appeared in two ways — as Madhava Puri and as Advaita Acharya — and Chandrashekhara, renowned on earth as Acharyaratna, became the disciple of them both. This does not diminish Advaita: He is Maha-Vishnu Himself, non-different from the Lord, and Madhavendra is His guru and the root of the tree of devotion.

Madhavendra's disciples in the line of the Madhva-sampradaya are Ishvara Puri, Advaita, Paramananda Puri, Brahmananda Puri, Ranga Puri, Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Raghupati Upadhyaya and others; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta names Ishvara Puri, Nityananda and Advaita as the chief among them. According to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (23–24), Ishvara Puri received from Madhavendra the fruit of madhurya, love in the conjugal mood, and Advaita the fruits of dasya and sakhya, service and friendship. It is said that Pundarika Vidyanidhi received initiation from Madhavendra at the same time as Advaita. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” sees in this discipleship the highest praise of Madhavendra himself:

“What more can I say of the devotion of one who became the spiritual teacher of Sri Advaita Acharya?” (CB, Adi 9.157)

And Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains why Mahaprabhu always honoured Advaita as an elder and a teacher: Advaita is the godbrother of Ishvara Puri, the Lord's guru.

Sita and Shri; Two Houses

Advaita married two daughters of Nrisimha Baduri (Bhaduri), a devoted brahmana — Shri and Sita. Vishnu has three shaktis — Shri, Bhu and Nila; without His shaktis Advaita too would not have revealed Himself in fullness. According to the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika," Sita is Yogamaya, and Shri is her prakasha, her manifestation[12]. The wedding with Sita took place in Phulia-nagara, and after it Advaita settled in Shantipura, in Nadia[13].

Advaita had two houses: in Shantipura and in Navadvipa-Mayapura, not far from the house of Srivasa. Navadvipa in those days was called "the Oxford of India," and in the Navadvipa house Advaita kept a tol — a Sanskrit school — and studied the scriptures deeply. He lived there from time to time and would talk of Krishna until dawn with the devotees headed by Srivasa. Seeing around Him people bereft of devotion to Vishnu, He taught the "Bhagavad-gita" and the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" and revealed their essence as devotional service.

The Call

Having returned to Bengal, Advaita became the head of its Vaishnavas. Around Him gathered Srivasa, Chandrashekhara Acharya, Gangadasa and others; Srivasa's brothers came to His house to hear the "Bhagavatam" and sing sankirtana. And Navadvipa all around was far from God. The learned were hostile to bhakti; they took for religion karma-yoga, rites performed for wealth; they taught the "Gita" and the "Bhagavatam" without a word about devotion; they were proud of birth and learning — and nowhere was the name of Krishna to be heard. The Vaishnavas headed by Advaita grieved.

The people of the age of Kali were indifferent to their only good — to the sankirtana of Krishna's name, and Advaita's heart overflowed with compassion. He wished to awaken the whole people to harinama, and He reasoned: a partial avatara would not be enough here — the world would be saved only if Hari Himself descended. The "Charitamrita" conveys His thoughts:

"My name Advaita will gain its true meaning only when I can induce Krishna Himself to perform sankirtana." (CC, Adi 3.101)

And He began to call the Lord. He worshipped Krishna with Ganga water and tulasi leaves — tulasi-manjaris — often fasted and gathered the Vaishnavas for common prayer; and He called loudly, with a "roar of love," prema-hunkara:

"Thinking of the lotus feet of Krishna, He began to offer Him tulasi-manjaris with Ganga water." (CC, Adi 3.107)

"And as He did so He called Krishna loudly, and this became the cause of Mahaprabhu's descent into this world." (CC, Adi 3.108)

"The main cause of Sri Chaitanya's descent is the plea of Advaita. The Lord, the Protector of dharma, comes only by the desire of His devotee." (CC, Adi 3.109)

Vrindavana Dasa says that this call was heard in Vaikuntha:

"He called out loudly to Sri Krishna. The sound of Advaita Acharya's voice pierced the coverings of the universe and was heard in Vaikuntha." (CB, Adi 2.82)

"Hearing the loving call of Sri Advaita, Lord Krishna appeared in person, for He is always captivated by the love of His devotees." (CB, Adi 2.83)

The "Bhakti-ratnakara" (12.3753–3764) sings of Him: Advaita's body is a treasury of the nectar of bhakti, non-different from the body of Chaitanya Himself; He brought Chaitanya down by His roar and then glorified Him everywhere; Advaita is non-different from Gauranga, and His consort Sita is the mother of the universe; whoever takes shelter of His feet will attain love for Gaura. So the cause of

Gaura's descent was Advaita's compassion for the people of Kali, His “audacious” call and the prayer of Haridasa, of which more below — and the Lord Himself confirmed this more than once.

The loud sankirtana angered the godless. They objected and threatened; they mocked: “The Lord sleeps through the four months of the rains — wake Him with your shouting, and there will be a great offence, and famine will come!”; they said that some brahmanas sing only to fill their bellies. When the devotees lost heart, Advaita encouraged them: the Lord will hear and will come.

Advaita and Haridasa

Long before the Lord's appearance Haridasa — by tradition, an avatara of Brahma — settled in Phulia, not far from Advaita's house in Shantipura. He lived in a cave and from time to time came to Advaita in Shantipura; so it was also after he had preached in Chandpur, in the house of Govardhana and Hiranya Majumdar. Haridasa was drawn by Advaita's talks, and Advaita recognised in him a bhajanandi who chants the holy name without cease. He built him a cave-like hut, explained the “Gita” to him every day in the spirit of steadfast devotion, nishtha-bhakti, and sent him prasada from His house. Haridasa spent most of his time with Advaita — in Navadvipa-Mayapura and in Shantipura; in His circle they grieved over the godlessness of the people, expounded the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” and sang kirtan.

Haridasa was born in a family of yavanas, yet Advaita honoured him as no one else would have dared. At the yearly shraddha for His father He offered a meal to the Lord, and the first dish, the shraddha-patra, which is given to the most honoured brahmana, He gave to Haridasa. The mahaprasada of the shraddha is presented to the honoured guest, and the “Charitamrita” says that Advaita so revered Haridasa that He let him be the first to taste the remnants of the memorial offerings in honour of His father (Adi 10.44). Haridasa was afraid, and Advaita answered:

“‘Do not fear, dear Haridasa. I shall certainly act in full accordance with the injunctions of the scriptures.’” (CC, Antya 3.219)

“‘You are so great that to feed you is equal to feeding ten million venerable brahmanas.’ Saying this, Advaita Acharya offered him to taste the offering He had presented to His ancestors.” (CC, Antya 3.220)[14]

From then on Haridasa dined at Advaita's house every day. For Advaita faithfulness to scripture stands above caution about caste: a Vaishnava is worthy of worship whatever family he is born in.

So the two of them together begged the Lord to come. Advaita worshipped Him with Ganga water and tulasi — in Shantipura and in Navadvipa-Mayapura — while Haridasa in his hut chanted the holy name and called on the Lord to appear; it is said that their prayer brought the Lord into the world in the form of Gauranga. The “Charitamrita” says:

“Advaita Acharya constantly pondered how liberation could be given to all the fallen souls of this world. He thought: ‘How can this whole world be saved, in which it is so hard to meet unselfish devotion to the Lord?’” (CC, Antya 3.221)

“Wishing to call into this world Sri Krishna, the Master of all creation, Advaita Acharya took a vow to worship Him daily with Ganga water and tulasi leaves.” (CC, Antya 3.222)

“In the same way Haridasa Thakura chanted the holy name of God in solitude, wishing to induce Krishna to descend into this world.” (CC, Antya 3.223)

“The holy devotion of these two Vaishnavas became the cause of the descent of Sri Chaitanya, who gave liberation to the whole world, calling all to sing the holy name of God and so attain divine love for Krishna.” (CC, Antya 3.224)

Later Haridasa moved to Navadvipa, wishing to live among pure devotees like Advaita.

The Lord's Appearance

Before coming Himself, Krishna sends into the world those whom He will honour as elders:

“First He sent to Earth all those close to Him and His elders. I shall list them briefly — to describe them all in detail is simply impossible.” (CC, Adi 13.53)

“Sri Shachidevi and Jagannatha Mishra, Sri Madhavendra Puri, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Srivasa Pandita, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Adi 13.54)

The Three Prabhus descend together with Their eternal companions — with Srivasa, Haridasa and others.

When Shachi was in the sixth month of carrying the Lord, Advaita came to Jagannatha Mishra, left him, and, reciting hymns and bowing, walked around Shachi — He was worshipping the Child in her womb. The astonished couple asked what this meant, but Advaita only answered that in due time they would know; and they did not understand.

On the evening of the Lord's birth, in Shantipura, Advaita together with Haridasa suddenly broke into a dance of joy, and no one knew why. It was the day of a lunar eclipse, and on that occasion many gifts were given away; about what had happened both kept silent[15].

Advaita sent Sita in a palanquin to the house of Jagannatha Mishra with a casket of precious cloth and ornaments, and with her husband's permission she came from Shantipura with gifts; seeing the superhuman form of the Infant, she was greatly amazed:

“Once the universally honoured Sita Thakurani, the wife of Sri Advaita Acharya, came with Advaita's consent to see the wondrous child, bringing various gifts with her.” (CC, Adi 13.111)

“Touching the baby's head with fresh grass and rice, she blessed Him with the words: ‘May both brothers live long!’ And to protect Him from witches and evil spirits she gave Him the name Nimai.” (CC, Adi 13.117)[16]

Sita often came from Shantipura to teach Shachi how to care for the Infant, and at the festival of His birthday she was the first allowed to offer the Child clothing. All the devotees together with Advaita and Sita prayed for the long life of the Child. Sita is worthy of worship equally with Shachi: her motherly love, vatsalya, for Gaura is of the same kind.

Nimai and Vishvarupa

The Lord was growing up in Navadvipa, and even the devotees were not sure that Nimai was Bhagavan Himself. Advaita, for His part, behaved as though He did not know Who He was — and wished more than anyone that the learned Nimai would become a devotee[17]. Nimai's elder brother, Vishvarupa, studied in Advaita's tol: every day, after bathing in the Ganga, He listened to Advaita's lectures and then Himself explained to those gathered that the essence of all scripture is devotion to Krishna, and Advaita, rising from His puja, would embrace Him. Whole days Vishvarupa spent in Advaita's house in talks on the scriptures of bhakti. Little Nimai used to run over to call His brother to lunch, and Advaita could not take His eyes off His face. Many years later He recalled:

“His elder brother, Vishvarupa, always used to come to Me before and discuss the ‘Gita’ with Me.” (CB, Madhya 2.21)

“As a child Vishvambhara was exceptionally beautiful. He always came to Me to call His brother, Vishvarupa.” (CB, Madhya 2.22)

“Enchanted by His beauty, I always blessed Him with the words: ‘May You attain bhakti.’” (CB, Madhya 2.23)

When Vishvarupa was twelve years old and His wedding was already being prepared at home, He left and took sannyasa with the name Shankararanya. Advaita grieved, but comforted everyone: soon Krishna Himself would appear; together with Sita He consoled Jagannatha and Shachi and helped them bring up Nimai. In Advaita's Navadvipa house the “Bhagavatam” was still read and kirtan sung, and everyone delighted in the voice of Mukunda Datta.

Ishvara Puri in Advaita's House

Once Ishvara Puri, a disciple of Madhavendra, came to Navadvipa unrecognised by anyone and entered Advaita's house:

“When Ishvara Puri, by the will of providence, arrived at Advaita's house, no one could recognise him in such dress.” (CB, Adi 11.72)

“He humbly sat down beside Advaita, who was performing puja.” (CB, Adi 11.73)

“The radiance of a Vaishnava is never hidden from another Vaishnava. Advaita looked at the guest and could not take His eyes off him.” (CB, Adi 11.74)

“Advaita asked: ‘Who are you, dear sir? I think you are a Vaishnava sannyasi.’” (CB, Adi 11.75)

The guest answered that he was lower than a shudra. Then Mukunda sang of Krishna, and Ishvara Puri fell unconscious in the ecstasy of love; Advaita embraced him and was Himself drenched with his tears, and on Him too the signs of ecstasy appeared. So Ishvara Puri and Advaita met, both disciples of Madhavendra, though Advaita only played that role[18].

The Dream about the “Gita”

When Nimai returned from Gaya transformed, with the signs of the highest devotion, Advaita, Srivasa and the other devotees rejoiced, and Advaita began little by little to reveal to them Who He was. He told the Vaishnavas His dream. Not having understood a verse of the “Gita,” He had fasted, and at night someone said to Him: get up, Acharya, and eat; the meaning of the verse is — worship Me alone; do not cause everyone suffering. And further — about the vow Advaita had made with arms raised:

“Why do You grieve? You have attained all You strove for. Your desire is fulfilled. That for which You kept fasts, performed worship and, weeping, chanted the names of Krishna has come to pass. You made an unbreakable vow to call down the Supreme Lord, and that Lord has now appeared.” (CB, Madhya 2.12–14)

Throughout the land, the voice said, Krishna-kirtan would resound, and by His mercy people would see a bhakti inaccessible even to Brahma (CB, Madhya 2.15–16). Opening His eyes, Advaita saw Vishvambhara — and He vanished. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” speaks of this in another place too:

“Having revealed to Advaita the true meaning of the verse of the ‘Bhagavad-gita,’ Vishvambhara closed that door leading to the path of bhakti.” (CB, Madhya 10.166)

The secrets of Krishna, Advaita added, He could not fathom — but let everyone wish that Nimai would surrender to Krishna. The devotees bowed to Him and began to sing the name of Hari.

Gadadhara Sees the Worship

Soon Gauranga came with Gadadhara to Advaita. Advaita cried out loudly, “Hari! Hari!” — and Gauranga fell unconscious. Then Advaita worshipped His feet with all the articles of puja and recited hymns to Govinda. Gadadhara objected: it is not fitting for an old man to worship a boy! “In a few days

you will know," Advaita answered. Coming to Himself, the Lord begged Advaita for mercy, and Advaita begged Him to lead them all in kirtan; and the Lord agreed.

Then Advaita withdrew to Shantipura: if Gauranga is Krishna, He Himself will draw Him to Himself. Advaita's mind is hard to understand — now He reveals Nimai, now He pretends not to know Him, now He "tests" Him and hides; but all this is so that the Lord should reveal Himself to the world[19].

"Nara!"

Soon the Lord revealed Himself to Srivasa. He kicked the door of his temple: "Whom are you worshipping? Here I am!" — and showed His four-armed form. "Because of your loud sankirtana, because of the persecution of the devotees and because of Advaita's audacious call," He said, "I have left Vaikuntha."

And on the eve of Nityananda's Vyasa-puja, at the kirtan in the house of Srivasa, the Lord began to call loudly: "Nara! Nara!" So He called Advaita, whose cry had brought Him down from Vaikuntha — and now Advaita lived without a care in Shantipura with Haridasa:

"Only because of Nara, whom you all know as Advaita Acharya, have I now descended into this world." (CB, Madhya 5.51)

"Nara called Me from Vaikuntha, and now lives without a care together with Haridasa." (CB, Madhya 5.52)

Another time the Lord would say that He lay in the Ocean of Milk and His sleep was broken by the roar of Nada (CB, Madhya 22.16)[20].

In Nandana Acharya's House

Soon after the Vyasa-puja the Lord, filled with the mood of the Supreme, sent Ramai Pandita, Srivasa's younger brother, to Shantipura: "Tell Advaita: He for whose sake He worshipped with Ganga water and tulasi, wept and fasted, has come. Nityananda too has come. Let Him come with His wife and with all that is needed for puja." Ramai could not utter a word for joy, but to Advaita everything was already revealed: "It seems Mahaprabhu has sent for Me," He said. And when Ramai delivered the message, Advaita raised His arms, wept and fell unconscious, and coming to Himself exclaimed:

"I have brought Him! I have brought My Lord! Because of Me the Supreme Lord has come from Vaikuntha!" (CB, Madhya 6.38–39)

Sita, little Achyutananda and all the servants wept with happiness too — and soon they set out[21].

But Advaita wanted the Lord to reveal Himself. To Ramai He said:

"If He shows Me His divine majesty and blesses My head with His lotus feet, I shall acknowledge Him as My eternal Master. I swear it shall be so." (CB, Madhya 6.47–48)

He resolved to hide — let the Lord find Him Himself. Coming to Navadvipa, He concealed Himself in the house of Nandana Acharya, and told Ramai to say that Advaita had not come:

"I shall stay secretly in the house of Nandana Acharya, but you tell Vishvambhara that I have not come." (CB, Madhya 6.57)

And this "test" too is a lila: in this way Advaita let the Lord reveal His omniscience to all.

The Lord, meanwhile, ascended the vishnu-khatta, the throne of Vishnu, in Srivasa-angana and proclaimed:

"Nara is coming! Nara is coming! He wants to behold My majesty!" (CB, Madhya 6.63)

Nityananda held an umbrella over Him, Gadadhara and others served. As soon as Ramai came in, the Lord said to him:

“Nara is coming here. He knows perfectly well Who I am, and yet He is always testing.” (CB, Madhya 6.68)

“I know perfectly well that Nara is now in the house of Nandana Acharya. He has sent you here to test Me.” (CB, Madhya 6.69)

And the Lord sent Ramai again — to Nandana's; so Advaita learned that there is no hiding from the Lord.

Advaita and His wife prostrated themselves before the Lord from a distance, and Advaita recited hymns. A vision opened to Him: the Lord in radiance, in the ornaments of which the dhyana-mantras speak; four-, five- and six-faced gods pray to Him; Ananta shades Him with His hoods, and the whole sky is full of gods and sages. The Lord said that He had come at His call from His rest in the Ocean of Milk (CB, Madhya 6.73–95). Advaita was struck dumb; then He washed His feet and worshipped Him with the five offerings, panchopachara, with the mantra “namo brahmanya-devaya…”.

He worshipped the Lord with various gifts — and the Lord, fulfilling His desire, placed His feet on His head, while all around cried, “Jaya!” At the Lord's bidding Advaita danced, forgetting Himself, and the devotees marvelled at such a dance at so advanced an age. One of the biographies adds that Advaita had brought Sita with Him and was the first of all to worship the Lord's feet.

The Lord placed His own garland on Advaita and told Him to ask for a blessing. “For Myself I have nothing to ask,” Advaita answered. “But let bhakti go to people of low station: those proud of learning, wealth, birth and renunciation only hinder the preaching” (cf. CB, Madhya 6.158–170). Advaita's desire is not for Himself: devotion is for the low, the unlearned and the fallen, for pride closes the way to it.

The Mahaprakasha

From then until the Lord's sannyasa Advaita lived together with Haridasa in His Navadvipa house, in Mayapura, every day attended the kirtan in Srivasa's house, and the two of them almost always engaged the Lord in kirtan. Another time, seated on the vishnu-khatta, the Lord ate all the offerings and the betel and called: “Nara!”; Nityananda held an umbrella over Him, and Advaita, His palms joined, recited hymns. The Lord told Him to ask for a blessing, for it was for His sake that He had come, and then embraced each one and wept for Krishna.

In the Mahaprakasha — the great revelation that lasted seven praharas, twenty-one hours — the Lord called each of the devotees, told him of his past and bade him ask for what he wished. Advaita said that He had nothing to ask. Then the Lord reminded Him of that dream about the verse of the “Gita” — and Advaita wept, for only He knew of it. “Be merciful to the unlearned and the fallen,” He asked; and, growing calm, He rejoiced that the Lord would regard Him as His servant.

Shantipura and the Bank of the Ganga

Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” tells of other days as well. The Lord sang kirtan in Advaita's house, and They embraced each other. Advaita came to Navadvipa, bowed to the Lord and danced, and at Srivasa's question the Lord expounded the truth about Advaita, advaita-tattva: “The shastras describe Him as Maha-Vishnu; know that this Advaita is the avatara in the form of a devotee” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 4, v. 98). Nityananda stayed two days as Advaita's guest, and Advaita worshipped the Lord in Srivasa's house. In Advaita's house the Lord told Him to preach love for Krishna without discriminating who is worthy of it and who is not; the devotees gathered there, and to all of them, headed by Advaita, the Lord entrusted the preaching.

Once, on the bank of the Ganga, Gauranga seated Gadadhara beside Himself, and Advaita performed arati to Them both. Before His sannyasa Mahaprabhu came more than once with Nityananda to Advaita's house in Shantipura and sang kirtan day and night. Parameshvari Dasa tells in a pada: the Lord sat in Advaita's temple, Nityananda and Advaita sat beside Him and playfully discussed the festival; Sita came in, smiling, and the Lord told them to call the Vaishnavas and prepare everything for kirtan.

Honour That Wounds

The Lord in His humility conducted Himself as one of the devotees, and honoured Advaita as a guru, as an elder: He fell at His feet and would not let Him touch His own. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains this by Advaita's being the godbrother of Ishvara Puri, the Lord's guru. But such honour gave Advaita pain.

Once, when the Lord lost consciousness in sankirtana, Advaita smeared Himself with the dust of His feet and worshipped them according to all the rules. Coming to Himself, the Lord in confusion threw Himself into the Ganga; Nityananda and Haridasa pulled Him out, and afterwards He lived for some time in another place[22].

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 17) tells of the same leap differently. Once the Lord felt no bliss in kirtan, and Advaita, without stopping His dance, said to Him:

“How will You feel ecstatic love, if Nara has dried it up?” (CB, Madhya 17.21)

“Neither I nor Srivasa have attained love for God. You enjoy Your pastimes of divine love with oil-sellers and gardeners. The Avadhuta has become the servant of Your love, while I and Srivasa are left out. We have no access to prema, whereas this Avadhuta has come and become its keeper. O Gosani! If You do not reward Me with Your prema, I shall dry up all prema. And there will be no fault of Mine in it.” (CB, Madhya 17.22–25)

Vrindavana Dasa at once explains that Advaita said this in the frenzy of prema, not remembering Himself — for Krishna increases the glory of His devotees (Madhya 17.26–27). The Lord decided there was no point in living without prema and threw Himself into the Ganga; Nityananda and Haridasa pulled Him out, and He secretly took shelter with Nandana Acharya.

The devotees searched everywhere for the Lord, while Advaita, considering Himself a great offender, went home and fasted from grief. In the morning the Lord told Nandana to bring Srivasa and at his request came to Advaita. Advaita lay without strength, almost unconscious[23]; but as soon as the Lord's voice sounded, He rose and broke His fast. He begged forgiveness for His audacious words and prayed:

“O Lord, grant Me the mood of loving service to You and keep Me at Your feet as the son of Your maidservant.” (CB, Madhya 17.83–87)

The Lord answered that Krishna punishes only one who is His servant birth after birth (Madhya 17.97), and Advaita, understanding that He had been punished as a servant, rejoiced: “From now on I can say that You are My Lord!” (CB, Madhya 17.100). In Nandana's house the Lord, Nityananda and Advaita all hid at one time or another.

The “Yoga-vasishtha”

The Lord's honour was a torment to Advaita, and He resolved to provoke His anger. He began to expound the “Yoga-vasishtha,” placing knowledge, jnana, and liberation above bhakti, and on some pretext went away to Shantipura. Advaita Himself says in the “Charitamrita”:

“Before, Mahaprabhu showed Me great honour as an elder. This state of affairs was not to My liking, and I devised how to change it all.” (CC, Adi 12.39)

“I began to explain the ‘Yoga-vasishtha,’ in which liberation is accepted as the highest goal of life. Learning of this, Sri Chaitanya grew angry and punished Me, forgetting His former respect.” (CC, Adi 12.40)

According to Srila Bhaktivinoda, He explained the path of knowledge to “a few unfortunate people.” Vrindavana Dasa conveys how it looked:

“Intoxicated with bliss, He constantly swayed from side to side, commenting on the book ‘Yoga-vasishtha’ and glorifying jnana.” (CB, Madhya 19.20)[24]

The Lord understood His design and went to Shantipura with Nityananda; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” They swam along the Ganga to Advaita's house, and the Lord threatened to show how He would punish Nara, who had brought Him down and was now hiding the glory of bhakti (Madhya 19.118–126). Seeing Them, Advaita began to extol jnana still more zealously. “Nara! Tell Me, which is higher — jnana or bhakti?” the Lord asked. “Jnana is always higher,” Advaita answered (CB, Madhya 19.131–132). Then the Lord dragged Him out into the courtyard and began to beat Him with His own hand (according to one of the biographies, with His fists), reproaching Him:

“If You wished to hide the path of loving service to God, then why did You become the cause of My descent?” (CB, Madhya 19.142)

Advaita's wife, the mother of the universe, understood what was happening, but still tried to stop the Lord (Madhya 19.135):

“He is an old brahmana! Spare His life!” (CB, Madhya 19.136)

And Advaita, having received the punishment, danced with joy: He understood that He had won, and rubbed His head against the Lord's feet. “My desire is fulfilled,” He said. “Before, the Lord was sparing with Me, honouring Me as an elder, but now He has dealt with Me as with a servant and saved Me from the heresy of mayavada.” The Lord, seeing through His ruse, was abashed, but was pleased and merciful to Him:

“Sri Chaitanya highly honoured Sri Advaita as His Guru on the path of bhakti. But Advaita Acharya Himself was greatly saddened by this.” (CC, Adi 17.66)

“Then Advaita began to explain the path of philosophical speculation, and Sri Chaitanya in feigned anger showed Him His disrespect.” (CC, Adi 17.67)

“Sri Advaita received this punishment as the greatest bliss. Understanding Advaita's motive, Sri Chaitanya was abashed and blessed Him.” (CC, Adi 17.68)

The Lord embraced Him: “I will be pleased with anyone, even one who has offended Me, if he takes Your shelter.” Advaita answered: “Whoever rejects You is nothing to You.” Little Achyutananda too saw his father's punishment.

Then the Lord called Advaita's wife mother and told her to prepare an offering for Krishna, and He Himself went with Nityananda, Advaita and Haridasa to bathe in the Ganga. Returning, He bowed down to Krishna, and then

“Advaita fell at the feet of Vishvambhara, and Haridasa fell at the feet of Advaita.” (CB, Madhya 19.232)

Rising, the Lord saw Advaita at His feet, quickly sprang up and exclaimed: “Vishnu! Vishnu!” (Madhya 19.234). Then the Three Prabhus sat down to their meal, and Haridasa by the door.

So Advaita's “path of knowledge” was only a ruse for the sake of punishment, not a conviction. He arranged this lila to show what a blessing punishment from the Lord, from the guru or from a Vaishnava

is. The highest thing for Advaita is to be a servant; honour from the Lord is a torment to Him, and for the sake of punishment He is ready to “preach” jnana and rejoice under the blows. And the Lord promises His mercy to anyone who takes Advaita's shelter — even an offender.

Shachi and Advaita

Shachi blamed Advaita for Vishvarupa's taking sannyasa. Before, she had kept silent, fearing to offend a Vaishnava — she knew Advaita to be a Vaishnava. But now Nimai too spent all His time in Advaita's house, leaving Lakshmipriya at home, and Shachi feared that He too would leave. In her sorrow she said to herself:

“Why is he called ‘Advaita’? In truth this Gosani is ‘Dvaita.’ He has already induced one son of mine to leave home, and now He wants to deprive me of my other son.” (CB, Madhya 22.113–117)

Only her Son knew of this.

Once, when the Lord, having revealed Himself, was seated on the throne and giving blessings to the devotees, Srivasa asked:

“Lord, we wish that You would grant ecstatic love for Krishna to mother Shachi.” (CB, Madhya 22.24)

The Lord refused: she had offended a Vaishnava, and only that Vaishnava himself can free one from such an offence — so Ambarisha freed Durvasa from it (Madhya 22.25–34):

“She has offended Nara, and therefore she will attain ecstatic love for Krishna only if Nara forgives her.” (CB, Madhya 22.35)

“Let her place the dust of Advaita's feet on her head, and then I shall grant her divine love for Krishna.” (CB, Madhya 22.36)

Hearing of this, Advaita said that Shachi was His mother, for from her womb His Lord had appeared, and began to glorify her — until He lost consciousness; then Shachi came, took the dust of His feet and herself fell unconscious with bliss. The Lord declared to her:

“Now you have attained devotional service to Vishnu, freed from the offence you committed against Advaita.” (CB, Madhya 22.52)[25]

So the Lord showed how grave vaishnava-aparadha is: it bars the way even to Shachi, and only the forgiveness of the offended Vaishnava saves one from it. And He showed that Vaishnavas are not proud: Shachi went without delay to beg forgiveness. Shachi herself is the eternal mother of the Lord, Yashoda; Vrindavana Dasa says plainly that in truth it was not even an offence, but the Lord called it so (CB, Madhya 22.58)[26].

The Universal Form

Once Advaita, sorrowful, was dancing in Srivasa's courtyard and lamenting that His hope had still not been fulfilled; only after two praharas, some six hours, could He be calmed. The Lord, seeing how He rolled on the ground and wept, led Him into the room of Vishnu, and Advaita asked: “Let Me see what Arjuna saw.” And before Him appeared the universal form, the vishvarupa: a dark-blue four-armed Krishna, in whose body were the luminaries, the seas and the mountains, millions of faces, arms and eyes; Arjuna was reciting hymns to Him, and Advaita, taking a blade of grass between His teeth as a sign of humility, begged for service (cf. CB, Madhya 24.33, 24.47–55).

The Drama in Chandrashekhara's House

When in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna the Lord staged a drama about Krishna, Advaita was given the role of the vidushaka — the jester: forgetting Himself, He “danced in various moods like

an experienced jester" (CB, Madhya 18.35–36). The Lord danced in the mood of Rukmini and then appeared as the Adya-shakti, the original energy, Lakshmi; Gadadhara too played Rukmini, Nityananda the Lord's grandmother, Srivasa Narada, Haridasa a watchman[27]. The Lord announced that only those who had controlled their senses could watch the drama, and Advaita and Srivasa sadly said that this meant they could not. But the Lord smiled and answered: "If you do not come, then who will be present during the dance?" (Madhya 18.24) — and reassured them:

"Today you will all become the greatest mystic yogis. Beholding My dance, none of you will be bewildered." (CB, Madhya 18.26)

Night Kirtans and the Procession to the Kazi

Advaita was beside the Lord in sankirtana — in Srivasa's courtyard, in the streets of Navadvipa and on the bank of the Ganga — and among those who sang all night long:

"All of them sang in jubilation: 'Krishna, Rama, Mukunda, Murari, Vanamali!'" (CB, Madhya 23.29)

"Nityananda and Gadadhara whirled, holding hands. Advaita, like a lion, ran about the room in ecstatic bliss." (CB, Madhya 23.30)[28]

When Chand Kazi forbade the sankirtana, the Lord led Navadvipa out into the streets, and Advaita led one part of the procession, dancing and loudly singing the names:

"The Lord danced as He moved along the bank of the Ganga, and all who walked beside Him sang the names of Lord Hari." (CB, Madhya 23.202)

"Advaita Acharya with His party went in front and danced in indescribable bliss." (CB, Madhya 23.203)

And the Kazi became a friend and vowed never again to hinder the sankirtana[29].

The Lord's Sannyasa

At the beginning of 1510 Mahaprabhu accepted sannyasa in Katwa. Intoxicated with love for Krishna, He wandered for three days, thinking He was going to Vrindavana, while Nityananda sent Chandrashekhara Acharya ahead:

"At that time Sri Nityananda ordered Chandrashekhara: 'Go quickly to the house of Advaita Acharya.'" (CC, Madhya 3.20)

"'I shall bring Sri Chaitanya to Advaita's house. But let Advaita wait for us with a boat on the bank of the Ganga.'" (CC, Madhya 3.21)

From there Chandrashekhara was to go on to Navadvipa for Mother Shachi and all the devotees (Madhya 3.22)[30]. The news of the Lord's sannyasa broke hearts, and, according to one of the biographies, Advaita wept until He fell down as though lifeless; then a voice from the sky told Him not to grieve: in a few days the Lord would be with them. Elsewhere the same biography says that, on receiving the news, Advaita went with Haridasa from Navadvipa to Shantipura.

"Wherever You Are, There Is Vrindavana"

Nityananda taught the cowherd boys to point out the road to the Lord so that it led Him not to the Yamuna but to the Ganga, opposite Shantipura. Taking the Ganga for the Yamuna, the Lord offered her a prayer and entered the water — and just then a boat came to the bank:

"Just at that time Advaita Acharya arrived by boat with new cloth for Sri Chaitanya." (CC, Madhya 3.30)

“‘Advaitacharya! Is it You? How did You come here? How did You know that I am in Vraja?’” (CC, Madhya 3.32)

“‘Truly, wherever You are, there is Vrindavana!’ the Acharya replied. ‘I am immensely fortunate that You have come to the bank of the Ganga.’” (CC, Madhya 3.33)

The Lord exclaimed that Nityananda had deceived Him by calling the Ganga the Yamuna; but Advaita objected that there was no deception: here the Ganga and the Yamuna flow in one bed, and along the western bank flows the Yamuna, so the Lord had truly bathed in the Yamuna (Madhya 3.35–37). He dressed the Lord in dry cloth, brought Him by boat to His house and washed His feet[31].

Advaita fell prostrate before the Lord and embraced His feet, and the Lord raised Him up. To Advaita and Sita, says one of the biographies, it was as though life had been given back.

Advaita's little son Achyutananda came running too. Vrindavana Dasa speaks of him thus:

“Advaita had a little son named Achyutananda, whose naked body seemed to radiate effulgence.” (CB, Antya 1.213)

“Understanding that the Lord had come, this child, covered with dust from head to foot, came laughing to see Him.” (CB, Antya 1.215)

“Coming, he fell at the lotus feet of Gaurachandra, and the Lord took this dust-covered child onto His lap.” (CB, Antya 1.216)

“The Lord said: ‘O Achyuta, Advaita Acharya is My father. Therefore we are brothers.’” (CB, Antya 1.217)

“Achyuta replied: ‘By Your own sweet will You have become the friend of all living beings, whereas the Vedas extol You as the father of all that exists.’” (CB, Antya 1.218)[32]

Ten Days in Shantipura

The Lord had eaten nothing for three days, and in Advaita's house a great feast was prepared for Him. Sita cooked, and Advaita offered everything to Vishnu; the rice lay in mountains on whole banana leaves. The Lord, says one of the biographies, after His fast accepted prasada from Sita's hands. At the meal Advaita joked with Him and with Nityananda, and Nityananda and Advaita began a playful quarrel: Advaita called Nityananda a “fallen avadhuta,” and Nityananda, as if in anger, threw a handful of rice — and Advaita danced with joy that the remnants of Nityananda's meal had touched Him. Such “disputes” of Advaita with Nityananda are lila: the one who seems to censure Nityananda in truth glorifies Him. When Advaita wished to massage the Lord's feet, the Lord stopped Him and sent Him to eat together with Mukunda and Haridasa (Madhya 3.105–107). On the following days the Lord ate Shachi's cooking as well.

The next morning Chandrashekhara brought Shachi from Navadvipa:

“On the morning after Mahaprabhu's arrival Chandrashekhara brought Mother Shachi in a palanquin. Many other devotees came with them as well.” (CC, Madhya 3.137)

The people of Navadvipa came as well; in Shantipura the Lord was visited by Gangadasa, Shridhara, Damodara, Nandana Acharya and others. For four days Sita did not leave Shachi, who lay as though at the point of death.

For ten days sankirtana never ceased in Advaita's house:

“All danced in jubilation, crying ‘Hari! Hari!’ Truly, Advaita's house became like Vaikuntha.” (CC, Madhya 3.156)

According to one of the biographies, at the evening kirtan Advaita danced holding on to Nityananda, with Haridasa behind Them. For many days Advaita fed and lodged the guests from Navadvipa and the surrounding villages:

“Inexhaustible were His stores. As soon as He spent anything, it was at once replenished.” (CC, Madhya 3.159)

Then, at His mother's request, the Lord resolved to live in Puri, and in that same year 1510 He went there, having encouraged the devotees, whom Advaita now led. For Advaita and all Navadvipa a time of separation began.

Every Year to Nilachala

From Puri the Lord set out to travel through South India. When Kala Krishnadasa brought to Bengal the news that He had returned, Advaita in jubilation cried out at the top of His voice, sang and danced much (CC, Madhya 10.78–80); one of the biographies says that this news as it were brought Shachi, Srivasa, Advaita and Haridasa back to life. The devotees gathered in Advaita's house and then, having received Shachi's permission in Navadvipa, set out for Puri (Madhya 10.85–88). Devotees from Shrikhanda came to Advaita's house as well, to travel together:

“Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana from Khanda also came to the Acharya's house, to go with Him to Jagannatha Puri.” (CC, Madhya 10.90)

Kaviraja Gosvami speaks of their first coming thus:

“In the year after Sri Chaitanya accepted sannyasa, all the devotees, headed by Advaita, set out for Jagannatha Puri to see Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Madhya 1.46)

“Having seen the Ratha-yatra, all the devotees stayed four months more, to relish the supreme bliss of dancing and singing the holy names in Sri Chaitanya's company.” (CC, Madhya 1.47)

“Taking leave of everyone, the Lord asked the devotees to come every year to the Ratha-yatra festival at the Gundicha temple.” (CC, Madhya 1.48)

According to one of the biographies, Advaita set out with Shachi's permission even before the Ratha-yatra, and the Lord sent mahaprasada ahead to meet the travellers at Cuttack[33].

Of the twenty-four years after His sannyasa the Lord spent six in travel and eighteen in Puri (Madhya 1.249), and all that time the Bengalis came to Him every year:

“And every year the Bengali devotees came to see Sri Chaitanya and stayed four months in Puri.” (CC, Madhya 1.250)

“The other devotees, headed by Advaita, Nityananda, Vidyanidhi, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and Srivasa, came to Sri Chaitanya every year and stayed four months in Nilachala.” (CC, Madhya 1.255)

And it was always Advaita who led them:

“The devotees set out for Nilachala under the leadership of Advaita Acharya.” (CB, Antya 8.6)[34]

Sita and Achyutananda went with Him.

The Meeting at Narendra-sarovara

One of the biographies tells that in Puri the Lord declared before all that He had descended into the world at Advaita's call — and the people of Puri were filled with devotion to Advaita. Learning that the Bengalis headed by Advaita had already reached Athara-nala, the bridge at the entrance to Puri, the Lord Himself went out to meet them; with Him were Kashishvara, Bhagavan Acharya, Pradyumna

Mishra and others. At Narendra-sarovara both sides fell prostrate before one another. “It is I who brought Him!” Advaita cried, and all bowed to Him. Nityananda and Advaita embraced, and the Lord, first of all, placed Jagannatha's garland on Advaita.

The Ratha-yatra and Gundicha

At the Ratha-yatra the Lord Himself divided the singers into groups and appointed a dancer for each — Nityananda, Advaita, Haridasa and Vakreshvara. In the first group the lead singer was Svarupa Damodara and the dancer Advaita. There was also the Shantipura group, which Advaita Himself had gathered; His son danced in it, and Gopala Mishra was in it too:

“In the group of singers from Shantipura, which Advaita Acharya had gathered, Achyutananda, Advaita's son, was chosen as the dancer. All the others were to sing along with Advaita.” (CC, Madhya 13.45)

Before the kirtan the Lord with His own hand adorned His senior companions with sandal paste and garlands:

“Advaita Acharya and Nityananda also felt immense happiness when the Lord's hand touched Them.” (CC, Madhya 13.31)

In other years too, going around the temple of Jagannatha in the bera-kirtan, the Lord formed seven groups:

“And in each of these seven groups there was a principal dancer, such as Sri Advaita Acharya or Nityananda Prabhu.” (CC, Antya 10.59)

“While in the other groups the principal dancers were Vakreshvara Pandita, Achyutananda, Srivasa Pandita, Satyaraja Khan and Narahari Dasa.” (CC, Antya 10.60)

In the days when Jagannatha stayed at Gundicha, the Lord sang with the devotees in the temple courtyard from morning till evening:

“At times He inspired Advaita Acharya, Nityananda, Thakura Haridasa and Achyutananda to dance.” (CC, Madhya 14.71)

And when the Gundicha temple was washed before the festival, everyone carried water except a few of the elders:

“All except Nityananda, Advaita, Damodara, Bharati and Paramananda Puri filled pots and carried water.” (CC, Madhya 12.109)[35]

Advaita also played with the Lord and the devotees in the water pastimes at Narendra-sarovara.

Among the Lord's companions in Puri Svarupa Damodara was especially dear to Advaita:

“He was very dear to Advaita and Sri Nityananda, and the very soul of the whole community of devotees headed by Srivasa Thakura.” (CC, Madhya 10.117)

Together with the Lord, Advaita also went to the garden of Tota-Gopinatha to hear Gadadhara Pandita read the “Bhagavatam.”

A Meal in the Storm

Once Advaita began to entreat the Lord to come to Him for a meal. He wanted to feed the Lord alone: when the Lord came with the sannyasis, out of respect for them He ate very little. Advaita cooked Himself, while His wife helped Him — cutting vegetables and handing Him the provisions brought from Bengal (CB, Antya 9.20–24)[36]. When the cooking was done, Advaita placed a tulasi-manjari on

every dish and sat down to meditate: let the Lord come alone.

Suddenly a storm arose — wind, downpour and hail — and the sannyasis, losing their way, did not reach the place, while at Advaita's it only drizzled a little. The Lord came alone and ate everything Advaita served Him. When He had eaten, Advaita began to glorify Indra:

"'O Indra! Today I have understood your greatness. Today I have understood that you are a Vaishnava.'" (CB, Antya 9.61)

But the Lord saw through Him: He asked why the Acharya was hiding the truth — was not this wind and rain the work of His hands? (CB, Antya 9.65) — and explained:

"You thought that if I came together with the sannyasis, I would not eat much." (CB, Antya 9.69)

"In truth Indra carried out Your order, so that Your real greatness would not be revealed to all. The chance to serve You is the greatest fortune for him." (CB, Antya 9.72)

Indra, the servant of Krishna, fulfils the desires of His devotees; if Krishna fulfils Advaita's desires, what wonder is it that Indra obeys Him? (cf. CB, Antya 9.73–74). One of the biographies places this meal in the third year, when the Bengalis came with their wives and brought foodstuffs with them.

A Kirtan in Glory of Gaura

The Lord would not allow Himself to be glorified: He called Himself only a servant of Krishna, and the devotees feared His anger. But one day Advaita told them:

"Today we will glorify no avatara other than Lord Chaitanya, Who is the source of all other avataras." (CB, Antya 9.159)

"I will dance, and all of you sing the glory of Lord Chaitanya. For if I sing as thunderously as a lion, I will frighten you all." (CB, Antya 9.162)

No one could disobey Advaita, and the devotees began to sing, while Advaita danced and sang a song He Himself had composed in glory of the Lord:

"'O Sri Chaitanya! You are Narayana Himself! You are an ocean of mercy and the friend of the distressed. Please be merciful to Me.'" (CB, Antya 9.168)

Hearing Himself glorified, the Lord was embarrassed and went home. When the devotees came to Him singing, He lay turned away and reproached them; and then He was answered that the sun cannot be hidden with one's palm — just so the truth about Him cannot be concealed (CB, Antya 9.204–208)[37].

Thus Advaita was the first openly to introduce kirtan in glory of Sri Krishna Chaitanya — honouring Him equally with Krishna, for He is Krishna. In this one sees Advaita's chief trait — spiritual fearlessness: it sounded in His loud call, in the shraddha-patra given to Haridasa, and in this kirtan.

Again in Shantipura: the Journey to Gauda

Five years after His sannyasa the Lord resolved to go to Vrindavana by way of Bengal. According to the "Charitamrita," He visited Srivasa in Kumarahatta, then Kulia, where He stayed a week in the house of Madhava Dasa and granted deliverance to crowds of people — even to sinners and offenders (the "Chaitanya-chandrodaya," 9.33, also speaks of those seven days in Kulia), and from there He came to Shantipura, to Advaita's house, and consoled His mother there. From Shantipura He went to Ramakeli, where He met Rupa and Sanatana, reached Kanai-natashala and returned again to Shantipura, staying there ten days this time (CC, Madhya 16.205–212)[38]. It is said that in those days Vamshivadana was born, and the Lord and Advaita were present at his birth.

Achyuta and the Question about Keshava Bharati

Even before the Lord came back from Ramakeli, a certain sannyasi came to Advaita's house and asked what relation Keshava Bharati bore to Sri Chaitanya. From the spiritual point of view the Lord has not and cannot have a guru; but Advaita reasoned that one may begin from the worldly side — so the Lord, Who has neither father nor mother, is glorified as the son of Devaki (one of the biographies adds: and Sandipani is called His guru) — and answered: “Keshava Bharati is Chaitanya's guru” (CB, Antya 4.146–151). Just then five-year-old Achyuta ran in, naked and all dusty from play. The “Charitamrita” tells:

“Hearing from his father that Keshava Bharati was Sri Chaitanya's teacher, Achyutananda was very upset.” (CC, Adi 12.14)

“Then he said to his father, Advaitacharya: ‘Your words that Keshava Bharati became Sri Chaitanya's guru bring ruin to our whole country.’” (CC, Adi 12.15)

“‘Sri Chaitanya is the Guru of the whole universe. Yet You say that someone is His teacher. But there is no confirmation of this in the scriptures.’” (CC, Adi 12.16)

“Advaita felt great joy when He heard the essence of the scriptural conclusions from His five-year-old son.” (CC, Adi 12.17)

According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” Advaita in bliss embraced His son, bathed him in tears of love and said:

“‘You are My father, and I am your son. You have appeared as My son in order to instruct Me.’” (CB, Antya 4.174)

He begged His son's forgiveness, and the boy, hearing himself praised, lowered his head in embarrassment. The sannyasi fell prostrate and exclaimed: “As the father, so the son!” (CB, Antya 4.177–178)[39]. Advaita danced together with His son: in His house an associate of the Lord had been born (4.184–187). Achyuta is an example of what a true son of Advaita is like: he cannot bear even worldly speech that belittles the Lord.

At that moment the Lord Himself arrived. Advaita fell prostrate before Him, crying “Hari! Hari!”; the Lord embraced Him and bathed Him in tears, and Advaita lost consciousness, and on coming to Himself seated the Lord. Advaita and Nityananda embraced. The Lord took Achyuta on His lap and washed the dust off him with His tears; He blessed the boy.

The Festival at Advaita's; Raghunatha

Advaita sent for Shachi. She came in a palanquin, and the Lord fell prostrate at her feet; she herself cooked for her Son. The festival in Advaita's house lasted several days, and no one knew where the provisions came from.

At that time Raghunatha Dasa came to Shantipura. His father Govardhana Majumdar respectfully served Advaita with gifts, and therefore Advaita presented the young man to the Lord:

“Raghunatha Dasa's father always respectfully served Advaita, and Advaita was favourably disposed to his whole family.” (CC, Madhya 16.225)

“So Raghunatha stayed in Advaita's house, obtaining the chance for about a week to serve Sri Chaitanya and to eat the remnants of Mahaprabhu's meals.” (CC, Madhya 16.226)[40]

Raghunatha had seen the Lord already on His first coming to Shantipura, after the sannyasa (Madhya 16.223), and later, in Puri, he also received Advaita's blessings. Now the Lord told him to go home and wait until He came back from Vrindavana.

Taking leave, the Lord told the devotees to come every year to the Ratha-yatra, and consoled Advaita: He hoped to see Him in Nilachala within that very year.

Nityananda's Wedding

Later, when Nityananda, then living in Bengal, agreed to marry, Advaita rejoiced: “Let it happen soon!” He was among the devotees at the wedding in Boroganchhi, and afterwards Nityananda with His wives, Vasudha and Jahnava, at Shachi's word stayed with Advaita in Shantipura, and Sita embraced them both.

Puri: the Following Years

On one of their visits — according to the “Charitamrita,” in the third year — the Bengalis took their wives to Puri as well:

“All the devotees set out under the leadership of Advaita Acharya, who joyfully anticipated meeting Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Madhya 16.13)

“That year all the devotees set out together with their wives, including the wife of Sri Advaita Acharya, the mother of Achyutananda.” (CC, Madhya 16.21)

All gathered at Advaita's house; He first took leave of Shachi and received her permission, and the travellers moved on to Nilachala, carrying the foods the Lord loved:

“Throughout the whole journey the devotees performed sankirtana, purifying all the places through which they passed.” (CB, Antya 8.41)

“Taking their wives, children and servants with them, the devotees went in great ecstasy to see Lord Chaitanya.” (CB, Antya 8.43)

Once the Lord, sending Shrikanta Sena, Shivananda's nephew, back from Puri, told him to tell the Bengalis not to come that year:

“I Myself shall come to Bengal this year and meet there with Advaita and all the devotees.” (CC, Antya 2.41)

“Advaita Acharya was already ready to set out, but on hearing this news He stayed at home.” (CC, Antya 2.45)

The month of Pausha passed, but the Lord did not come (Antya 2.46–47).

One of the wonders of Puri concerned Advaita's son Gopala. When, on one of the Bengalis' visits, the Gundicha temple was being washed, the Lord told him to dance, and the boy fell unconscious in prema and stopped breathing. Advaita laid him on His lap; together with the devotees He loudly chanted the mantra to Nrisimha and sprinkled His son with water, but the boy did not come to himself, and all wept. Then:

“Mahaprabhu placed His hand on his chest and loudly said: ‘Gopala, get up!’” (CC, Madhya 12.148)

“Hearing this, Gopala came to himself, and the devotees began to dance and sing the holy name of God.” (CC, Madhya 12.149)

The “Charitamrita” tells of this in the Adi-lila as well (12.19–26).

Kamalakanta Vishvasa

Kamalakanta Vishvasa, Advaita's servant and disciple, without His knowledge wrote to King Prataparudra that Advaita was the Supreme Lord Himself, but by the will of fate had run into a debt of three hundred rupees, and asked the king to pay this debt. The letter reached the Lord. He said that to

call Advaita the Supreme Lord was no mistake, but to present the Supreme Lord as a poor beggar was a disgrace, and He told Govinda no longer to let Kamalakanta in to see Him (CC, Adi 12.29–36). Kamalakanta grieved, but Advaita rejoiced and told him that he did not understand his immense good fortune: for it was the Supreme Lord Himself — Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu — who had punished him (Adi 12.38). And Advaita went to the Lord to "complain" that He had shown Kamalakanta more mercy than He had shown Him (Adi 12.43–45). The Lord laughed, called Kamalakanta and instructed him:

"An acharya-Vaishnava must never take gifts or money from kings and the wealthy. He must never eat food from the hands of materialistic people, for this pollutes the mind." (CC, Adi 12.50)

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains: although Advaita is God Himself, in this world He plays the role of a man in order to teach people. It is shameful for an acharya to beg from a king, and a teacher of the holy name takes no payment for it. And Kaviraja Gosvami says that these confidential exchanges were understood only by Advaita and the Lord: only the Lord grasped the essence of Advaita's intention, and only Advaita appreciated the full depth of the Lord's instruction (Adi 12.48, 12.54).

Mercy to Rupa; the Debt of Love

When Rupa Gosvami came to Puri, the Lord Himself brought him to Advaita and Nityananda and asked Them to bless him:

"Then Sri Chaitanya turned to Advaita Acharya and Nityananda: 'With all Your heart You must bestow Your mercy on Rupa.'" (CC, Antya 1.56)

And Advaita with Nityananda and all the devotees bestowed mercy on Rupa and embraced him (Antya 1.207)[41].

In the year when Nityananda too came with the Bengalis — against the Lord's order to remain in Bengal — the Lord, at the end of the four months of the rains, taking leave of the devotees, said of Advaita, "Acharya Gosai":

"To grant Me His mercy, Advaitacharya too has come here. Because of His love I am in His debt, and this debt I am unable to repay." (CC, Antya 12.70)

And then He addressed everyone: for My sake you have left your homes, wives and children and walked a hard road; I am a penniless sannyasi, and I have nothing to give you but My body — this I give to you (Antya 12.71–74)[42].

The Riddle

Every year the Lord sent Jagadananda Pandita to Nadia to console Shachi. Once, having stayed there a month, Jagadananda came to take leave of Advaita, and Advaita sent with him a message to the Lord — a riddle, a tarja, understandable to Him alone:

"Tell the madman that all the people have gone mad. Tell the madman that rice is no longer sold in the market." (CC, Antya 19.20)

"Tell the madman that the mad one is no longer occupied with worldly affairs. Tell the madman that a madman has said this." (CC, Antya 19.21)[43]

Hearing the riddle, the Lord smiled slightly, said, "Such is His order," and fell silent. To the question of Svarupa Damodara, who himself knew its meaning, He answered only that the Acharya is a great knower of worship according to the agamas: for the puja He invokes the Deity, and when the worship is finished He sends Him away — and the meaning of the riddle, said the Lord, even He could not understand (Antya 19.23–28). Svarupa Damodara grew sad: from that day the Lord's separation from Krishna became twice as strong, and His divine madness grew (19.29–31). One of the biographies sees

in this a sign that the Lord's pastimes in this world were soon to be concealed.

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura reveals the meaning of the riddle: all are already intoxicated with prema, and the purpose for which Advaita called the Lord has been achieved; now the Lord is free to act as He pleases[44].

Sons

One of the biographies counts six sons of Advaita. The eldest is Achyutananda, after him Krishna Mishra and Gopala Mishra: these three grasped the essence of their father's teaching and were devoted to Gaura; according to the “Advaita-charita,” they were born of Sita, and they are called the “three jewels” of Gaura. The fourth son is Balarama, the fifth Svarupa, the sixth Jagadisha; they did not accept Sri Chaitanya[45]. The “Charitamrita,” listing the branches of Advaita's tree, speaks of this thus:

“Unhusked rice is first measured together with the husk. But afterwards the husk must be winnowed away and the rice cleaned.” (CC, Adi 12.12)

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains in the “Amrita-pravaha-bhashya”: in the course of time some of Advaita's followers adopted other teachings, but the essence is the teaching of Advaita Himself, and whoever transgresses it will attain nothing:

“The instructions of the teacher are the basis of spiritual life. One who transgresses his orders cannot make any progress.” (CC, Adi 12.10)

“But those descendants of Advaita Acharya who accepted the path of Sri Achyutananda were all great devotees of God.” (CC, Adi 12.73)

“And all those who received the mercy of Sri Advaita easily found shelter at the lotus feet of Sri Chaitanya.” (CC, Adi 12.74)

Vrindavana Dasa says the same still more sternly:

“If a person worships Advaita but neglects Gaurachandra, he dooms himself to ruin, even if he is Advaita's son.” (CB, Antya 4.183)

Achyutananda, according to the “Charitamrita,” is a great branch of Advaita's tree: from his very birth he served the feet of Sri Chaitanya (Adi 12.13). The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (87–88) calls him the darling of Krishna-Chaitanya and the beloved disciple of Gadadhara Pandita and sees in him Karttikeya and the gopi Achyuta — both are true, for the two are united in one (others consider Krishna Mishra to be Karttikeya). One of the biographies gives the year of his birth as 1428 Shaka (1506), and the place as Shantipura[46]. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in the “Anubhashya” calls Achyutananda the first of Advaita's disciples, while the “Shakha-nirnayamrita” calls him a disciple of Gadadhara. In the Lord's last years, according to the “Charitamrita,” he remained living in Jagannatha Puri, having taken shelter at the feet of Sri Chaitanya (Adi 10.150); according to one of the biographies, Advaita's other sons also lived there at that time.

Yet another biography mentions “Sri Nrisimha, the son of Advaita Acharya,” who lived in Ramakeli[47].

According to one of the biographies, Achyutananda and his brothers Krishna Mishra and Gopala lived in celibacy, serving the Lord's mission, while Advaita's line continued from His other sons, who did not follow the Lord. The same biography says that Balarama and his descendants rose against the teaching and that Srila Vishvanatha Chakravarti contended with them.

Disciples

Advaita's mercy extended also to those who were bound to Him as disciples. Yadunandana Acharya of Chandpur, the guru of Raghunatha Dasa, was a close disciple of Advaita; Srinatha Chakravarti, the guru of Kavi Karnapura, a sub-branch of His tree; Padmanabha Chakravarti, the father of Lokanatha Gosvami, a dear follower of His. Kamalakanta Vishvasa, of whom we have told above, was also Advaita's disciple.

Another biography also names as Advaita's disciples Balarama Acharya of Chandpur — the priest of Hiranya and Govardhana, in whose house Haridasa lived (CC, Antya 3.164–167) — and Padmanabha together with his wife. The late "Prema-vilasa" tells that the "conqueror of the quarters" Bada Shyamadasa, defeated by Advaita in debate at Shantipura, received from Him the Krishna mantra and became known as Bhagavata Acharya (24.186–191); it was he who arranged Advaita's marriage (24.331–334). (According to the "Charitamrita," Bhagavata Acharya is a branch of Gadadhara Pandita, Adi 12.80.)

Concealment

When and where Advaita concluded His pastimes in this world, most of the biographies do not say. According to the "Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana," it was in 1559, in the hundred and twenty-fifth year of His life (see above, "Appearance in Shrihatta"); the biographies do not name the lunar day of His departure, and in our calendar there is no day of Sri Advaita's departure[48].

It is known that Advaita remained in the world even after the Lord's concealment, and concealed Himself before Sita. Srinivasa, returning from Puri, where he no longer found Gadadhara Pandita, learned on the high road from people of Gauda that Advaita and Nityananda too had concealed Themselves, and in grief resolved to give up his body; but both Prabhus appeared to him in a dream and consoled him ("Bhakti-ratnakara," 3.325–358). Entering Shantipura, he again saw Advaita: He appeared to him and consoled him. And Sita, barely alive in separation from her husband, placed her feet on his head, blessed him and entrusted him to Madana-Gopala — Advaita's Deity (4.63–79)[49]. Advaita came to Srinivasa in dreams later too: He told him to marry — even before Narahari told him the same.

In Shantipura the service was continued by Advaita's sons. Achyutananda, Gopala and Krishna Mishra received Jahnava there; in Advaita's house Narottama spent two days with Achyutananda and bowed to him, and Krishna Mishra received Virachandra with honours and sankirtana. At the great festival in Kheturi were Achyutananda, Krishna Mishra and Gopala from Shantipura; and when kirtan was sung there, the Lord Himself appeared with His associates — both manifest and already concealed — and the "Bhakti-ratnakara" (10.573–604) exclaims: how Advaita and Nityananda shone in ecstasy!

Places of Remembrance and Books

In Ramakeli, in the temple of Madana-mohana, the Deity of Advaita is worshipped together with Nitai-Gauranga. In Mayapura, on the site of Advaita's Navadvipa house, in 1932, on the day of Gaura-purnima, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati laid the foundation stone of a new temple; the Advaita-bhavana in Mayapura became a centre of the Gaudiya Math.

About Advaita were written the "Advaita-mangala," the "Advaita-vilasa" and the "Sita-charitra"; Sarvabhauma Bhattacharya composed in His glory the "Advaita-dvadasha-nama," the "Advaitashtaka" and the "Advaita-ashtottara-shata-nama." Most fully He is spoken of in the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," the "Bhakti-ratnakara" and the "Advaita-vilasa"; there is also the late "Advaita-prakasha"[50].

Advaita in the Memory of the Devotees

Advaita's name sounds wherever Sri Chaitanya is sung of. He is glorified by the benedictions at the beginning of the chapters of the "Charitamrita" and by the verse "jaya advaitadi…"; the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" glorifies Him too at the beginning of the ninth chapter of the Adi-khanda; Vrindavana Dasa says that the Lord descended into the world amid Nityananda, Advaita and Gadadhara. His name is in the Pancha-tattva mantra: "sri-krishna-chaitanya prabhu-nityananda sri-advaita gadadhara srivasadi-gaura-bhakta-vrinda." The "Bhakti-ratnakara" recalls Him at the kirtan at Shridhara's (12) and tells how Narottama prayed to Advaita together with other associates of the Lord (1). He is remembered in small things too: one evening it was to Advaita that Haridasa confessed he would no longer go preaching with Nityananda — so unpredictable were the avadhuta's pastimes. And in every list of the companions at the Ratha-yatra Advaita is among the first.

So the life of Advaita Acharya closes in a circle. His call, full of compassion for the people of Kali, brought down the Lord; His fearlessness revealed to the world Who Sri Chaitanya is; His humility showed how a servant seeks not honours but punishment from the Lord; and His riddle announced that the purpose was fulfilled — the world was intoxicated with prema. Whoever takes shelter of His feet will, in the words of the "Charitamrita," easily find shelter at the feet of Sri Chaitanya.

1. The "Charitamrita" says this too: maya manifests in two ways — as the efficient cause and as the material elements; Vishnu, glancing at maya, is the efficient cause of the world, while in the form of Sri Advaita Narayana Himself becomes its material cause (CC, Adi 6.14–17). This does not mean that the Lord turns into matter or is subject to maya: the parts of God's body and all His manifestations, as the "Charitamrita" stresses, are wholly spiritual and have no connection with maya (Adi 6.23). He only empowers the elements with His potency, and Himself remains the Master of maya.

2. One of the biographies gives the reference to these verses as Adi 7.94–97; correctly it is Adi 7.14–17.

3. Sadashiva here is not the demigod who governs the destruction of the world, but a manifestation of the Lord Himself in Vraja (as the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika" itself calls him); therefore the words about Sadashiva do not contradict Advaita's being Maha-Vishnu: both truths speak of His divine nature. And Lochana Dasa, having called Advaita Mahesha, at once explains: this great Maheshvara is full of sattva, and only the world, judging by externals, calls Him "tamo-guna"; the mundane tamo-guna is cast away from among His qualities (CM, Sutra-khanda, part 8, vv. 602–604).

4. One of the biographies refers these explanations of the names to Adi 6.26 and 6.30–31; correctly they are Adi 6.25 and 6.28–30.

5. In the Bengali text of the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" the nickname sounds as "Nada" (nāḍā); the biographies and translations usually render it as "Nara." One of the biographies interprets "Nara" as "one who sets in motion" — this is the author's own interpretation.

6. So she is called by one of the biographies and by the "Bhakti-ratnakara"; another biography calls her Nagadevi, and the late "Advaita-prakasha" calls her Labha Devi.

7. This is the view of one of the biographies, which its author considers the more probable; Navagrama near Sylhet is also named as the birthplace by the "Bhakti-ratnakara." The "Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana" names the village Laura (Lauda), from which Advaita supposedly moved to Sylhet and then to Shantipura. According to the "Prema-vilasa" and some other lives, He was born in Shantipura itself.

8. Only these late works give the years of His appearance and departure; the other biographies do not name them. Our calendar has no day of His departure.

9. The late "Advaita-prakasha" names Advaita's teacher as Shanta Vedantavagisha of Purnavati; whether he is the same person as Shantacharya is unknown.

10. According to one of the biographies, Advaita received Madhavendra's "invitation" while still on pilgrimage, before He came to Vraja; elsewhere the same biography, following the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," says that Madhavendra himself came to Advaita's dwelling long before the Lord's appearance. The third version is that of the "Charitamrita": the meeting in Shantipura on Madhavendra's journey for sandalwood.

11. One of the biographies says that before meeting Madhavendra Advaita taught jnanavada, the path of abstract knowledge — just as Mahaprabhu before Gaya was above all a master of grammar and logic and defeated Keshava Kashmiri — and from then on preached Krishna-bhakti wholly. If this report is accepted, it too is only part of the lila: Maha-Vishnu cannot stray into jnanavada. And the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Antya 4) relates that even before Madhavendra's arrival Advaita was explaining the "Gita" and the "Bhagavatam" as the teaching of bhakti.

12. "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika," 86 (one of the biographies wrongly gives 81–84). One of the biographies, in its chapter on Advaita, names only Sita; it speaks of Shri only in its account of Sita, referring to the "Bhakti-ratnakara."

13. One of the biographies, referring to another, calls Sita Paurnamasi in the lilas of Krishna; but according to the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika," Paurnamasi is Govinda Acharya.

14. Elsewhere the same biography says "thousands of brahmanas"; the "Charitamrita" speaks of ten million.

15. According to another account, Jagannatha Mishra on the eve had sent word to Advaita in Shantipura, and Advaita and Haridasa bathed in the river, danced and sang, and Sita was sent to Mayapura; according to yet another, Advaita, having come from Shantipura, understood that Hari Himself had appeared and explained this to Srivasa and others.

16. One of the biographies refers this episode to verse Adi 13.112; correctly it is Adi 13.111 and 13.117.

17. One of the biographies says that Advaita, enchanted by the boy's beautiful face, did not recognise the Lord in Him. This concealment is part of the lila performed by His own will: Maha-Vishnu, non-different from Hari, cannot fail to know the Lord, but, as another biography says, He "pretends not to know," so that the Lord should reveal Himself at the proper hour.

18. One of the biographies names Advaita's temple as the place of the meeting; another adds that later Gauranga met Ishvara Puri there too — but according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Adi 11), the Lord met him on the road.

19. The "test" of which the biographies speak is not doubt. Advaita knows Who Gauranga is and Himself tells the Vaishnavas of it; His "test" is a lila by which He compels the Lord to reveal Himself to all.

20. So according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 5.15, 5.23: the kirtan on the eve of the Vyasa-puja) and one of the biographies; another refers it to the very day of the Vyasa-puja. In one of the biographies the Lord's words are referred to verses "CB 2.9.297–298"; correctly they are CB, Madhya 22.16 and 5.51–52. In our Russian translation Madhya 22.16 reads "by the loud weeping of Advaita"; the Bengali text has "nāḍāra huṅkāre," "by the roar of Nada."

21. So according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 6.36–44). The biographies tell this story in parts: one says that Advaita, raising His arms, danced, and in another place that He fainted with joy; two of them name among those who wept Advaita's son Achyutananda as well.

22. So in one of the biographies — the cause of the leap is named as the dust of His feet, which Advaita took without leave. Other accounts — including the same biography in another chapter — following the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 17), name a different cause — Advaita's words about prema. According to the "Chaitanya-mangala" (Madhya-khanda, part 9, vv. 64–69), the dust of the Lord's feet was taken not by Advaita but by a certain brahmana (in Murari Gupta, 2.11.21, a brahmana woman), and the Lord, playing the role of a devotee, grieved at having received an honour befitting the Lord.

23. According to one of the biographies, the Lord, seeing Advaita, felt Himself at fault, and according to another, considered Himself a great offender; according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 17.50–51, 17.77) it was Advaita who considered Himself a great offender. Neither is a mundane guilt: Vrindavana Dasa says that the Lord, having punished Advaita, "in the end felt great compassion for Him" (Madhya 17.66), and Krishna's punishment is a sign that the one punished is His eternal servant (17.97).

24. The "Yoga-vasishtha" is a book permeated with the teaching of mayavada. Advaita expounded it not from conviction: both Vrindavana Dasa and Kaviraja Gosvami say that it was a ruse, devised so that the Lord would stop honouring Him as an elder and would punish Him as a servant. Those close to Him knew it: Haridasa, "knowing Advaita perfectly well," laughed aloud on hearing His praise of jnana (CB, Madhya 19.25), and Advaita's wife, interceding for Him, "understood what was happening" (19.135). And the "blows" here are not a mundane reprisal but a lila in which the Lord answers His servant's desire to be punished.

25. So according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 22.20–52). The biographies tell the circumstances differently. According to one of them, Srivasa asked for Shachi the darshana of the Lord's form, during the Mahaprakasha; the Lord answered: "Mother has offended Advaita — I will not show Myself to her," Shachi went herself to beg Advaita's forgiveness and, having received it, saw the Lord's form. Another, closer to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," speaks of prema and of the vishnu-khatta and writes that Advaita lost consciousness, astonished that the mother chosen by the Lord Himself could be at fault before Him.

26. Shachi's "offence" is part of a lila performed for the sake of a lesson; one of the biographies calls it an "extraordinary means" chosen by the Lord. Neither Shachi nor Advaita is subject to worldly feelings: Vrindavana Dasa explains at once (Madhya 22.118–123) that the Lord wished, by His mother's example, to warn everyone against vaishnava-aparadha and to establish Advaita as a Vaishnava — against those who would glorify Him as Krishna Himself.

27. According to one of the biographies, Gadadhara played a gopi; according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," the Lord gave Gadadhara the role of Rukmini (Madhya 18.9), and he danced "in the garments of Rama, the goddess of fortune" (18.112), while at the end of the drama it was the Lord Himself who became a gopi (18.219). Another biography adds that the Lord said He would not dance at all without Advaita and Srivasa (cf. 18.24).

28. One of the biographies says that Advaita rushed about "holding on to Nityananda and Gadadhara"; according to the text of the "Chaitanya-bhagavata," it was Nityananda and Gadadhara who held hands, while Advaita ran like a lion.

29. One of the biographies places this account in the section on Advaita's life after the Lord's sannyasa; according to the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Madhya 23), the procession to the Kazi took place before the sannyasa. The order of the parties in

the procession is given differently by the sources (see the article on Srivasa).

30. So according to the “Charitamrita.” One of the biographies says that the Lord Himself sent Chandrashekhara, the husband of His aunt, to console Navadvipa, although elsewhere the same biography follows the “Charitamrita”: it was Nityananda who sent Chandrashekhara for Shachi and the devotees.

31. One of the biographies tells of the way to Shantipura differently: the Lord Himself sent Nityananda to bring the devotees of Mayapura to Advaita's house, and He Himself came there by way of Phulia, where crowds met Him — even blasphemers. Here the account follows the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 3).

32. One of the biographies, referring to Vrindavana Dasa, says that Achyutananda was then either three or five years old. In the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” itself he is here a “little son” (Antya 1.213), and he is called five years old in the account of Keshava Bharati (Antya 4.153). The biographies render this conversation in their own words: “If Advaita is My father, then you are My brother” — “The scriptures say that You are the father of all.”

33. According to the “Charitamrita,” this was “in the following year” after the sannyasa. One of the biographies, having quoted this verse, at once adds that probably about three more years had passed.

34. One of the biographies refers this verse, as well as the account of the same journey with families (CB, Antya 8.39–43), to the “Charitamrita” (“CC 3.8”), and the verse about the yearly visits (Madhya 1.255) to “2.9.255–256”; correctly they are CB, Antya 8.4–6, 8.39–43 and CC, Madhya 1.255.

35. The translation has “Damodara”; the Bengali text here reads “Svarupa,” that is, Svarupa Damodara, and “Bharati” is Brahmananda Bharati.

36. So according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 9.21, 24: Advaita Himself cooked, and His wife assisted Him) and two of the biographies. According to a third, on one of the visits to Puri the Lord's favourite dishes were cooked by Sita, and it was she who invited Him; it says nothing of the storm.

37. One of the biographies puts these words in Advaita's mouth; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 9.204–208), it was Srivasa Pandita who answered so: he made as if to hide the sun in his palms, and laughed.

38. The “Charitamrita” mentions both stays with Advaita — before Ramakeli and after. The biographies speak now of one, now of the other, and differ in the order of the journey: according to one, after the South the Lord passed through Kulia, then Ramakeli, and only then returned to Shantipura; according to another, He stayed a few days with Advaita and went to Ramakeli, and from Advaita, as the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says, to Srivasa in Kumarahatta; according to a third, the Lord stopped at Advaita's on the way back from Kanai-natashala, and Balabhadra and Damodara are named as being with Him — but, according to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 17), Balabhadra Bhattacharya accompanied the Lord later, on the way from Puri to Vrindavana. And according to the “Chaitanya-mangala” (Shesha-khanda, part 6, vv. 57–58), the Lord, returning from Vrindavana, came to Shantipura, to Advaita's house, spent a day and a night there in the joy of kirtan and next morning left for Nilachala; according to the “Charitamrita,” He returned from Vrindavana by way of Prayaga and Kashi, and visited Kulia and Shantipura on the way to Vrindavana.

39. Advaita's response is told differently. According to the “Charitamrita” (Adi 12.17), He rejoiced at His son's words; it does not mention the sannyasi. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” speaks both of Advaita's bliss (Antya 4.172) and of His calling His son His father and begging forgiveness; it was Achyuta, according to it, who felt ashamed (Antya 4.176). One of the biographies in one place writes that Advaita was ashamed, and in another, following the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” that He was plunged into an ocean of happiness and called His son His father. Even if the first report is accepted, Advaita's shame is the same play as His “worldly” answer: He, Maha-Vishnu Himself, knows that the Lord has no guru, and arranges this conversation to reveal to the world His son's faith. Therefore the boy's reproach too — whether maya had not overcome his father (CB, Antya 4.159–161) — does not mean that Advaita is subject to maya: Maha-Vishnu is her Master.

40. One of the biographies speaks of five or six days; the translation of the “Charitamrita” has “about a week,” and a little further (Madhya 16.234) “a whole week.”

41. One of the biographies says that the Lord asked Advaita and Nityananda to bless Rupa and Sanatana. According to the “Charitamrita,” the request for mercy concerned Rupa (Antya 1.56–57), while Sanatana the Lord later only introduced to Advaita and the other devotees (Antya 4.108).

42. One of the biographies renders these words (Antya 12.71–74) as though the Lord were speaking them to Advaita; according to the “Charitamrita,” only verse 12.70 concerns Advaita, and after it the Lord addresses all the Bengali devotees.

43. One of the biographies refers the riddle to verses 19.19–21 and renders its last line differently: “madmen are good for nothing.”

44. The concealment of the Lord's pastimes takes place only by His own will. The image of the Acharya who invokes the Deity for worship and then sends Him away speaks not of a servant's power over the Lord, but of the oneness of will between the Lord and His eternal associate: the Lord came at Advaita's call and by His own will concludes His pastimes when their purpose is achieved.

45. The sources give the number of sons differently. Six sons — in one of the biographies; the “Charitamrita” also names six: Achyutananda, Krishna Mishra and Gopala as branches of Advaita's tree, and as “other sons” Balarama, Svarupa and Jagadisha (Adi 12.13–27). Another biography says that Sita bore three — Achyutananda, Krishna Mishra and Gopala; a third names only Achyutananda.

46. Another biography gives “about 1505.” Both years agree poorly with the primary sources: according to the “Charitamrita” (Adi 12.17) and the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4), Achyuta was five years old when he objected to his father about Keshava Bharati — already after the Lord's sannyasa, while the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls him a small child as early as 1510 (Antya 1). The year of his birth therefore remains unclear.

47. A son of this name is named neither by the other biographies nor by the “Charitamrita” in its list of Advaita's sons (Adi 12).

48. The year 1559 and the age come only from these late works (see note 8). The late “Chaitanya-mangala” of Jayananda and the “Advaita-prakasha” also tell of Advaita's departure after the Lord's concealment, but their information calls for caution.

49. Elsewhere the same biography says that when Jahnava came to Shantipura before the festival in Kheturi, neither Advaita nor Sita was any longer in the world.

50. Only this late book, whose information should be treated with caution, tells in detail of Madana-Gopala — the Deity whom Advaita served; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.79) mentions Madana-Gopala in Advaita's house in Shantipura: Sita entrusted Srinivasa to Him.